

The Sun and its family

The star we know best is the Sun. Like all other stars in the sky, the Sun is an enormous ball of hot, glowing gas. It has its own “family” of planets, including our home—the Earth!



*Spots often appear on the Sun's face.
They are areas of cooler, dark gas.*

Close for comfort

We are nearly 93 million miles (150 million km) away from the Sun—that's close enough for us to learn a lot about it.

If we were much closer, we would be roasted alive. The Sun is the only star we can see in detail. Astronomers use special equipment to study it. By learning about the Sun, we learn more about the other stars in the Universe.



Gigantic clouds of hot gas called prominences leap out from the Sun.

Mercury Venus

Earth

Mars



Sudden bursts of hot, bright gas are called flares.



Jupiter